

This is my first semester at the University of North Georgia and taking upper-level history classes in-general; so, it is important for me to outline my goals and assess them on a frequent basis to ensure success in this course. To assess any goals, I must first review my academic (and personal) background as it may relate, the expectations I carried when walking into this course, and the anticipations I have for the course after a week of coming to full-class discussions. From this, I have created a general outline answering the questions that can assist me in my goals for the course and how I can achieve them.

What made you take this course?

The concept of Public History is one that members of the public rarely consider when they hear the word “History” as an academic study. Many, including myself before I decided to seriously engage in historical learning, assumed that the study of history involved little interpretive work. The rationale behind this seems correct on a strictly surface level understanding: how can facts be in dispute? The reality is that the nuances of History are more complex than simply regurgitating facts. Once someone has a more accurate understanding of how history is taught, they can then see that History (the academic study) is controlled by the teacher.

I’ve had many discussions with peers and acquaintances about the misteaching of history, and it’s always led to the same conversation: how did we get here? How did some facts get reported and others get omitted? Who decided the standards on the pedagogy of history? These are questions that anyone wanting to become a Historian, or just educated in history in-general, must come to terms with if they wish to be successful. From the few lectures I’ve attended so far into the course, the answer to these questions surprised me. I’ll cover this more in a later section.

What assumptions do you have about the public history at the beginning of this course?

Going into this course, I expected that the process of public history would have a more defined teaching on a “good” way to handle history. Basically, I assumed that there were “correct” and “incorrect” ways of handling history for public consumption. It was in the first lecture that I quickly learned that we are probably never going to see an “objectively correct” answer to any question even remotely related to public history. There will never be a “Yes, you’re correct” and instead this course will be guided around “That’s an interesting interpretation.” This will be something I will adjust to.

I was also walking into the course with the assumption that there would be more of a defined “science” as to how we arrive at the misteaching of history. In my mind, humans are objective creatures always looking for the truth even if it’s an ugly one – especially in terms of history. In some cases, it may take time for the objective truth to finally be confronted. It took years for the Soviet Union to admit fault in Chernobyl after the incident, but they eventually grappled with truth. I have since learned that this is not entirely true and is more dependent on the reader. Sometimes people are poisoned by mistruths before the actual truth can reach them, sometimes it’s just a matter of how to interpret history, and sometimes people just like lies because they have ulterior motives. I’m hoping we cover more on this in the future, but this class is about the politics of public history so we will mostly be covering the final one in the list.

How do you anticipate meeting the learning goals set by me?

In terms of the learning goals outlined in the course syllabus, the readings are most helpful to me. In general, I am more of a reader than I am a discussor of history. This is mostly because I believe reading is a more efficient tool to engage with a concept than discussing it. Mostly because I think discussing is a way to nurture and enrich a teaching, but not a good way

to actually teach it. Then again, I'm also the eccentric student who prefers lectures and PowerPoints, which I know most of my peers disagree with. I could be the odd one out in this regard.

Podcasts are also helpful for daily reinforcement of the materials we review both in and outside of class. Unless the podcast is listed in the pre-reading for the course, it's helpful to play an episode in the car or during studies to help engage my learnings and provide new perspectives when it comes to learning about public history.

What additional learning goals do you want to set for yourself in this class beyond those in the syllabus?

In addition to the learning goals stipulated in the course syllabus, I also want to engage more in the local history of Dahlonega, the University of North Georgia, and Lumpkin County. I am from Northwest Georgia in an area somewhat rich in local history, but Dahlonega seems to have way more of an expansive history than where I came from. Most classmates in the course seem to be from around the local area so they use local Dahlonega history as a frame of reference during class discussions. Considering this, I would be best served to learn more about local history for the city, county, and school.